

» YOGESH KATHUNIYA

Category: Athletics (Men's Discus Throw F56)

After clinching a silver medal at the Tokyo Paralympics, discus thrower Yogesh Kathuniya found himself in a bit of a "silver rut," unable to reach the top spot on the podium. In Paris, he again finished with a silver medal — but there's no room for complaints, given the tough couple of years leading up to the event.

At just nine years old, Yogesh was diagnosed with Guillain-Barré Syndrome (GBS), an autoimmune condition that attacks the body's nerves. It left him wheelchair-bound for two years. At the time, walking again, let alone playing sports, seemed like a distant dream.

However, his parents, Meena Devi, a homemaker, and Gyanchand Kathuniya, a retired Indian Army officer, refused to give up on him. Meena even learned physiotherapy to aid her son's recovery, and sure enough, within three years, Yogesh was back on his feet.

In 2016, at the age of 19, Yogesh discovered para sports with the help of Sachin Yadav, the General Secretary of the student union at Kirori Mal College. From that moment, there was no looking back.

Yet, 2023 brought new challenges. Yogesh contracted chickenpox early in the year and was later diagnosed with cervical radiculopathy affecting the C4, C5, and C6 vertebrae. Despite these setbacks, he fought through to win a silver at the Asian Games. His silver medal-winning throw of 42.22m in Paris was his season's best — a performance that has only intensified the 27-year-old's hunger for gold.



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SILVER

» MONA AGARWAL

Category: Shooting (Women's 10m Air Rifle Standing SH1)

Mona Agarwal, along with Avani Lekhara, took the podium in the women's 10m air rifle standing SH1 event, which is for pistol shooters with movement affected in the arms and/or the lower trunk and legs, or those with missing limbs. Mona, who contracted polio at nine months old, affecting both her legs, won bronze in her first Paralympic Games.



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BRONZE

After exploring several para-sports, including shot put, discus throw, javelin, and weightlifting, and pioneering women's sitting volleyball in India, Mona transitioned to para-shooting in late 2021. In 2024, the 37-year-old mother of two became a Paralympic medallist.

In 2023, she won gold in the Para Shooting World Cup in New Delhi, which also helped her secure a spot for the Paris Paralympics. She then partnered with Aadithya Giri to win a silver medal in the mixed team air rifle standing (SH1) event. The Lower Division Clerk in Jaipur District Court followed that with another gold in the Para Shooting World Cup in Changwon, Korea, one month later.